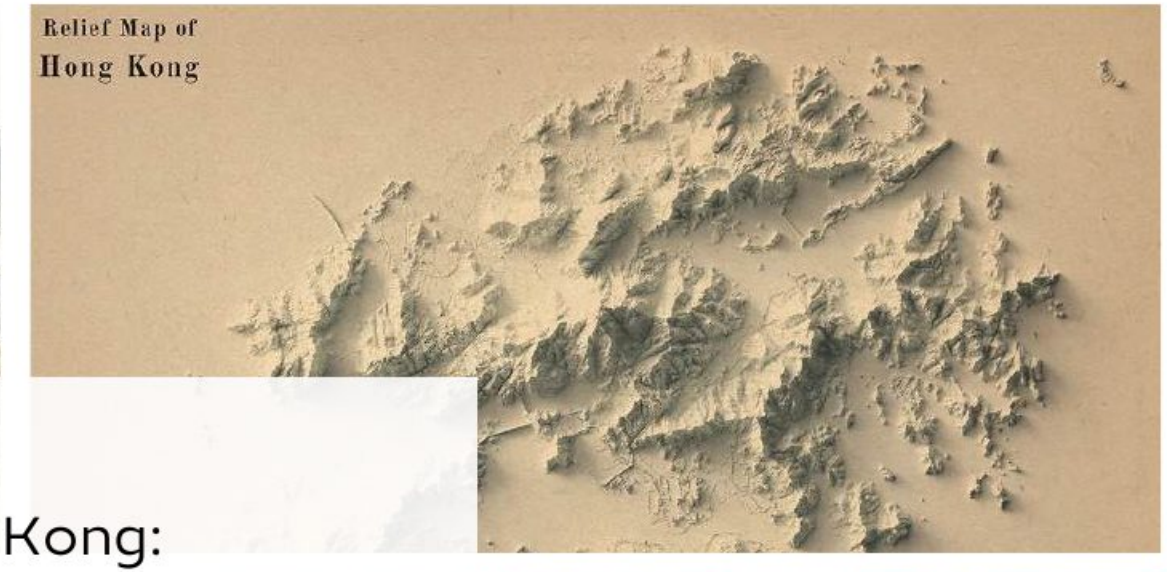
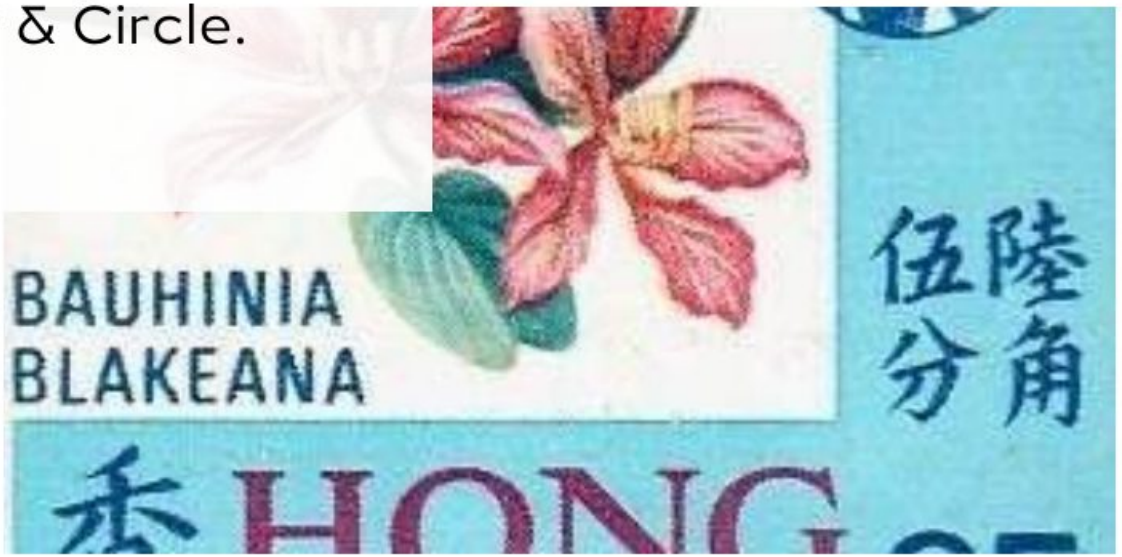




Hong Kong:
City, Center & Circle.





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Yin & Yang: Nature & Buildings

The Importance of Mutation and Change

SLIDE 1 | If, as a foreigner, you never had the chance to see Hong Kong, you nevertheless — with high probability — saw some first images of the city. And, if you type "Hong Kong" in your search engine, the first images that appeared are the following (cf. slide). Those images are deeply rooted in our shared imagination—those of a city that presents, on the one hand, a condensed nature. And on the other hand, a condensation of buildings.

SLIDE 2 | However, in line with our theme of femininity in motion, we must never stop at first appearances, which is what our project is all about. And whilst exploring more photographic projects and captures of Hong Kong, you quickly realise that nature is intrinsically linked to urbanism; and vice versa. One welcomes the other. The two intertwine, evolving together in a constant movement.

SLIDE 3 | This constant movement, this interconnection between two opposites that seemingly ignore each other, remind us of the yin and yang symbol. It also reminds us of the movements, among others, of Tai Chi, where movement and immobility, construction and storage, engage in a continuous dance that finds its visual embodiment in the yin and yang symbol. According to some thinkers, yin and yang were two fish swimming peacefully against each other, still causing energy waves in the water around them (even) when they rest (and thus, are yin).

SLIDE 4 | The architecture of Hong Kong thus suggests that female energy — which is not specific to a single gender defined by its primary appearance — is in constant motion. The vision we have of Hong Kong as foreigners or the vision of Hong Kong as foreign reminds us of the appearance of what we do not know and which is *exotic* to us, which seems different, and separate. Yet, the foreign, the other, is not different, not separate, but *also lives within us*. That the opposites are side by side, they require to be accepted so that the individual can *evolve towards his own wholeness and completeness*.

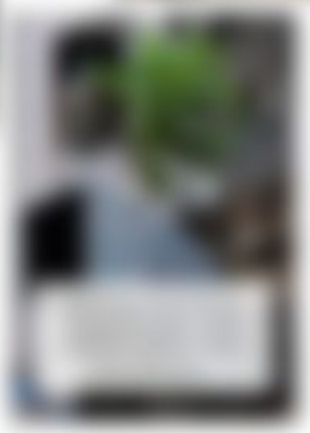
N. B. — To establish a parallel with Greek mythology and Western thought, it is interesting to quote the story of Dionysus, Bacchus in Roman terms. He (the other, the foreigner, symbolic of chaos and disorder) sits in the pantheon of the gods (the here, the known, symbolic of cosmos and order); yet he is the outsider, the chaos needed within the cosmos. Because, without the chaos, cosmos alone equals Thanatos (death). As women, the yang / as men, the yin can be seen as the stranger outside but also residing within us, waiting to be accepted and fully integrated within ourselves so that be become one, complete.























The Island Myth: An Odyssey to the symbolism of the Center.

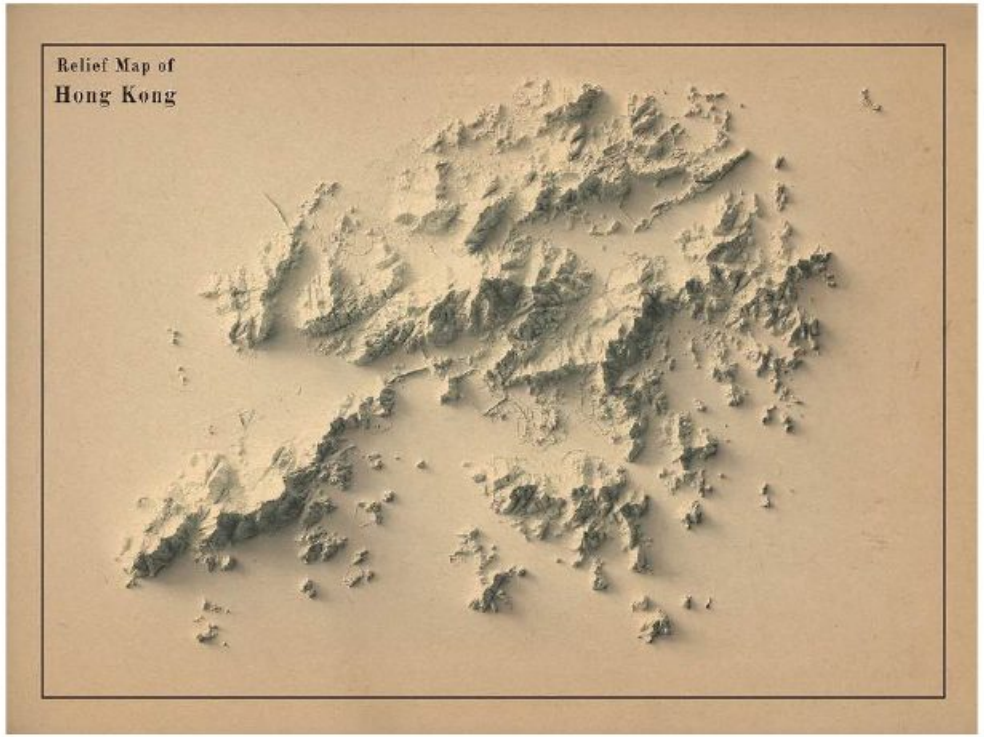
Against the rolling waves of the ocean,
one seeks the rescue of the rock.

SLIDE 1 | Part of Hong Kong is an island. Thus, our research led us to search for a definition of the island in the local culture, imagination, mythology and cosmogony. Islands play a fundamental role in most of our world's collective imaginations, stories and mythologies. However, it is crucial to consider these myths in the light — not only — of our own history, but ALSO of the geography and topography of the concerned country.

SLIDE 2 | In the West, most major cities were ports with quick access to the waters, and many islands were accessible or inhabited. Islands are part of our myths and our history, and have been physically known for millennia. In China, *this point varies*. Throughout history, islands were considered more as *unknown continents, far from land, difficult to access*. And therefore, *tainted with mystery*. The islands are, however — in two different ways — part of the historical and cultural heritage of both the East and the West. In China and Hong Kong, the legend of *the Islands of the Immortals* — amongst which the most famous is *Penglai* — was widely spread. It was said that they could only be reached by *flying*. Therefore, only the eight immortal gods could reach them, and live there. Over time, Taoism came to associate islands with the *home of gods*, and Buddhism came to associate islands with *dragon kings*. As the maritime activity increased, so, too, did fiction regarding *sacred islands of adventure*. People started to see islands and archipelagos as special and *home to immortality*. Thus, emerged... *The myth of the elixir of immortality*.

N. B. — It is interesting to note that in the western heritage, the dragon, or ouroboros — sometimes dragon, sometimes snake, borders are blurred — is an alchemical symbol of the completion of the cycle of reincarnation to reach unity, the union between opposites, the circle. In other words, the fusion between yin and yang, the fusion between our feminine and masculine parts.

SLIDE 3 | These mythological stories — very far from remaining only written in books preserved in inaccessible libraries — have infused the Chinese — and Hong Kong — history and culture. Expeditions were led during ancient times by emperors who, convinced of the existence of these islands, sent sailors in search of these mysterious islands. Magical mariner compasses were developed then, and various books narrate these (sometimes) epic adventures.



SLIDE 4 | Still today, those tales are illustrated in comic books, designer illustrations, contemporary artists' works, and even animation films broadcasted on Netflix...

SLIDE 5 | However, is it really just about a quest for virgin islands, inhabited by immortals or home to the elixir of immortality? In Honk Kong, unlike in the West, *the landscape is intrinsically linked to the individual*. And the quest for the island could therefore be likened to *a pursuit of one's own inner island*, one's centre, one's unity. Unity including ones own yin but also yang part. The quest for the elixir of immortality could perhaps be compared, with humbleness, to the pursuit of the philosopher's stone; or knowledge.

Of self-knowledge, above all, intrinsically linked to knowledge of the world not only inside, but also outside of us.























Chinese Cosmogony: the Symbolism of Square & Circle.

from Huainan Zi to Brutalism.

SLIDE 1 | Browsing through visuals of Hong Kong architecture — with a foreign eye — can led to an observation. The circle and the square motif seem recurrent—sometimes discreet, but seemingly omnipresent. Brutalism, an architectural style that emerged in the 1950s in UK, characterised by exposed raw concrete and bold geometry, spread globally in the 60s and 70s. Including in Hong Kong.

However, it seems that such comparison might be too simple, and perhaps *reductive*...

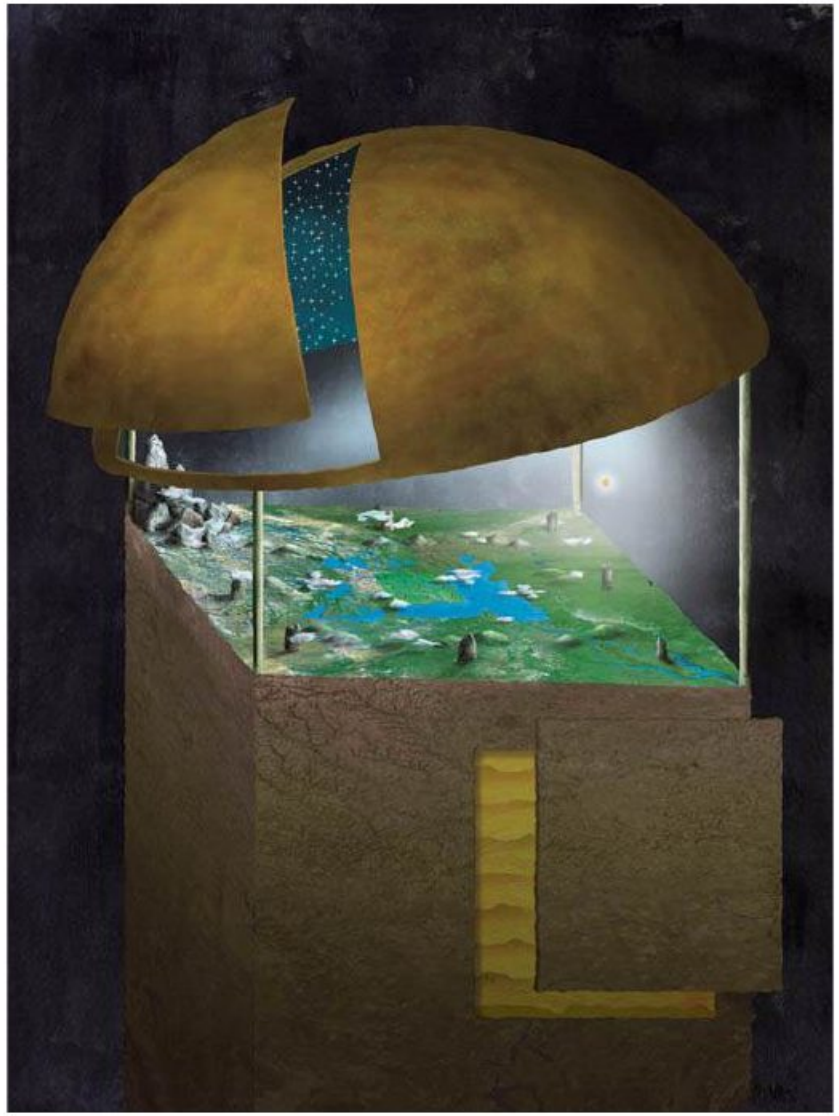
SLIDE 2 | Especially when you discover some unique architectural details, which are very surprising for a westerner. Namely, the *dragon holes*, which you all might know very well.

SLIDE 3 | Digging deeper, we can learn that the circle and square motif were present long — very long — before the arrival of brutalism. In particular, it was already present in the second century BC, with the writing of Huainan Zi, which describes the country's cosmogony.

SLIDE 4 | In a book that illustrates cosmogonies of the world, based on ancient writings, it can be surprising to see that the *only* cosmogony that had neither the shape of a circle, nor the shape of a round, or an egg, was the country's cosmogony.

SLIDE 5 | It is a square, for the base of the earth, topped by a dome, like a bowl, for the sky. According to the legend, the god Pan Gu, who was sleeping in an egg, woke up and formed the earth and the sky with the yolk and the white of the egg (both symbolic of the yin and the yang). The divinity Nǚwā, sister of Fuxi, is said to have created humans from clay.

Here, in the centre, is the drawing that the illustrator named earlier made of this Chinese cosmogony. It would later significantly influence the rich symbolism present in all areas of China: from sacred works to everyday objects.





Bauhinia × blakeana | 洋紫荊
The symbolism of Flower(s).

SLIDE 1 | The bauhinia blakeana flower, the symbol of Hong Kong, present on its flag, is quite interesting to explore. It is an orchid, the only flower that is — seemingly — not used in perfumery for its fragrant properties. In the art of scenting, it is considered to have no scent.

The orchid has the symbolism of driving away evil spirits. Its five petals, and its circular aspect, can, in parallel, evoke the centre of the magic square, or the feminine number.

In the West, its symbolism is equally fascinating to explore. The word orchid comes from the myth of Orchis, son of a nymph and a satyr. At one of the bacchanalian parties set by the god Dionysus (which we explore in the Cartier myths), he seduces a priestess. The gods punish him for this unforgivable mistake in the Greek pantheon. Pardoned at the request of his parents, he will eventually be transformed into an orchid, which will become a symbol of fertility.

This strong link that the orchid maintains, in the east and the west, between the feminine and the masculine, intrinsically linked to its representation, is particularly interesting to explore in the context of the feminity in motion project.

